Getting to know people the easy way

Career fairs are an increasingly popular recruitment channel for companies. They also offer many opportunities for job seekers. Here's how to get the most out of them.

TUM TIP

You have the chance to get to know different companies at IKOM, the career forum at TUM: *www.ikom.tum.de*

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Prepare:

Find out beforehand which companies will be exhibiting at the fair and what items in the program, such as presentations or case studies catch your eye. Do your research at home on any companies that whet your appetite. You can often get basic information like the number of employees or the company's business activities straight from the fair's own website. The more details you have at your fingertips, the better. For example, about the managers, the company's business units, new projects, the share price, new products or its competitors.

Prepare documentation and take it with you:

Summarize your CV on one to two pages and take some copies with you. (You can learn more about how to compose your resume in Chapter 3). Once you arrive at the employer's stand and you have introduced yourself, you could get some specific feedback from the recruiters. Things such as where they see your future and any points in your CV where they have questions. It may also make sense to print some business cards.

Prepare the right outfit:

It will pay off to put some thought into your appearance. At the very least, you should choose Business Casual, in other words jeans with a shirt or blouse, jacket or blazer. You never know if you might suddenly find yourself talking to your future boss.

Have conversations that will be well remembered:

Here's what to do once you arrive at the fair. Get an overview, identify the people you most want to talk to and put your questions to them. For example: What do you expect from someone in the position of a software developer? What career paths are open to someone in controlling? How am I to picture an average working day in the department for engine development? By the way, if you get to the fair in the morning, you will usually have a better chance of having in-depth conversations. Think beforehand about how to introduce yourself briefly while managing to mention the skills you've acquired so far and your career goals. The first step is to get their attention, maybe by mentioning what you have to offer. Get them interested and maybe emphasize your unique selling points, your USPs. You can find more information on how to introduce yourself successfully on page 166 under "Tell us about yourself." After the interview, jot down a few details, such as the name of the interviewer and useful hints you got.

Stay in touch:

At each career fair, you can collect valuable contacts even if your application comes to nothing. You never know where you are going to end up and what doors will open for you in your life. So get in touch with all of these contacts, if possible, after one or two days by email. For example, you could put: "Good morning Ms/Mr Müller, we met at the XYZ fair. You were kind enough to present your company to me. I am enclosing my CV. I would be delighted if we could stay in touch. Kind regards, XY"

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